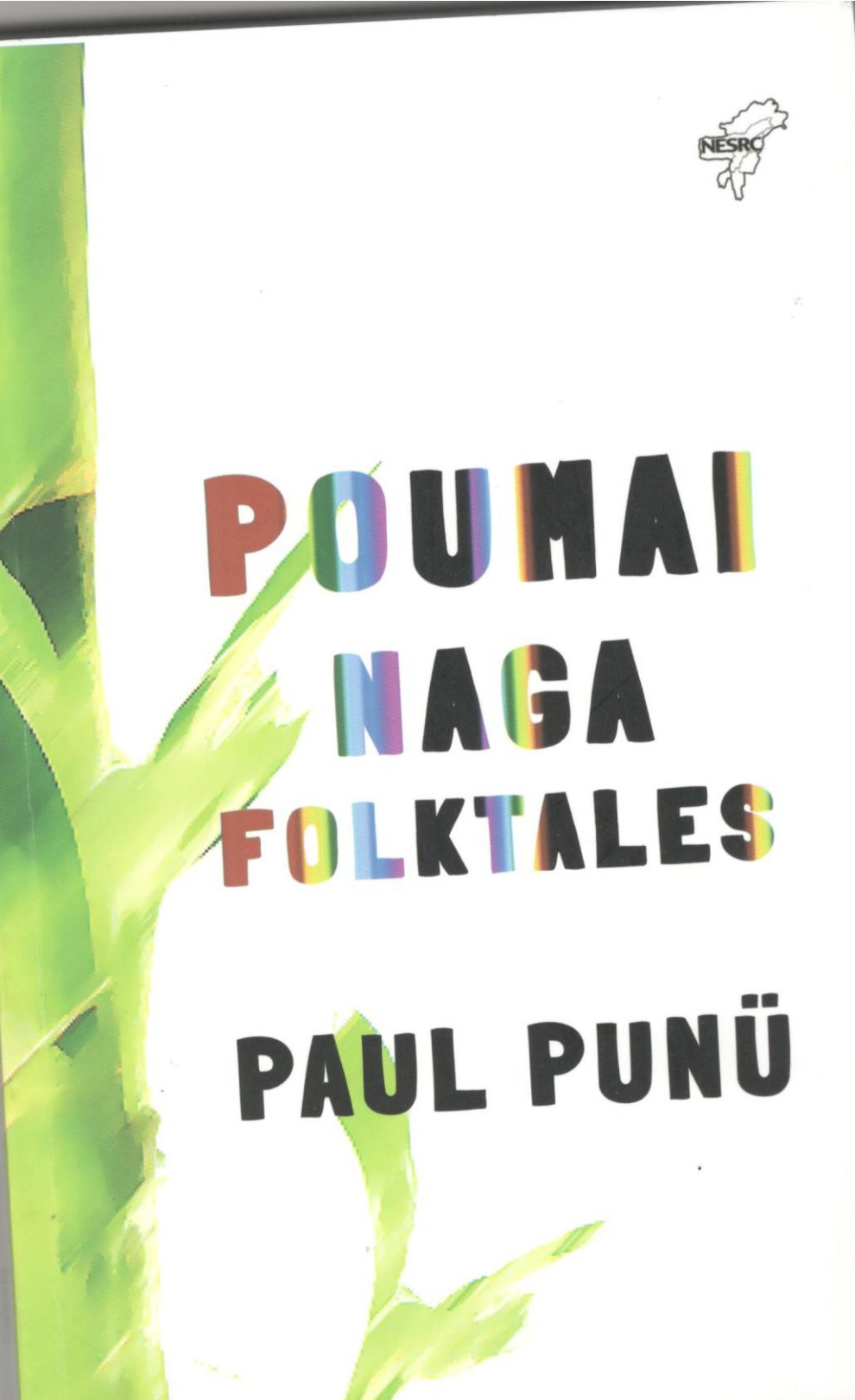

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Poumai Naga Folktales

Paul Punü



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INTRODUCTION

As I bring out this book, *Poumai Naga Folktales*, I would like to locate these tales in the Poumai Naga country. The narration of these folktales would be an exercise in futility if they are isolated from their social and cultural context. Hence, let me begin with a brief profile of the Poumai Naga community and a description of Poumai homeland followed by a sketch of the social organisation and cultural features of the Poumais, as also an account of their principal festivals and cultural events. With this information as a background, I do hope the message contained in the Poumai folktales will become clear and even relevant to our times.

1. The Poumai Nagas

At the outset, it is important to note that the term 'Naga' used to identify a large number of tribal communities living in their mountainous homelands in the present day states of Nagaland, the hills of Manipur and contiguous areas of other North Eastern States as well as Myanmar is an exonym. This name was given by outsiders to a large number of different

tribal communities. Traditionally, these people never thought of themselves as 'Nagas', but rather as members of their own communities probably on the basis of their distinct language such as the Angamis, Lothas, Tangkhuls, Memeis (Maos) and Poumais. Each of these communities has its own culture or way of life, customs, styles of leadership, and language. It was only after World War I that a sense of common aspirations formed among many of these communities.

The Poumai Nagas are a very old tribe living on both sides of the border between the present states of Manipur and Nagaland. The word 'Poumai' is the tribal name of the Poumai Nagas and is made up of two words: 'Pou' and 'mai'. 'Pou' is the name of the great male progenitor or ancestor of the tribe, and 'mai' means people or descendants. Hence, a literal translation of the word 'Poumai' would mean 'people of Pou' or 'descendants of Pou'. Poumai Naga people speak a language called *'Poula'* which literally means the language spoken by the people of 'Pou'. *Poula* belongs to the Tibeto-Burman language family and falls under the sub-group of Naga languages. The *Poumai* Naga tribe was given separate recognition as a Scheduled Tribe by an Act of the Parliament of India which received the assent of the President of India on the 7th of January 2003 (*The Gazette of India*, 2003). Until that time, the Poumais were clubbed together with the Memei/Mao Naga tribe as is seen in the list of Scheduled Tribes of Manipur in Part X of the Constitution of India. In the past they were referred to as Sopvoma by their neighbours and by themselves (Hodson, 1988, p. 3).

In 2011, the total population of Poumai Nagas was 179,189 as recorded in the Census of India. Their homeland covering an area of about 1,200 sq. km, is divided into four circles: *Paomata, Chilivai, Lepaona* in Senapati district of Manipur and *Razeba* in Phek district of Nagaland. The Poumai homeland is bounded in the north by Chakhesang of Phek district in Nagaland, the Thangal villages of Saikul Sub-division of Senapati District in the south, Tangkhul villages of Ukhrul District in the east and Mao-Maram Sub-division of Senapati District in the west. According to Louno Andrew, Chairman (1998-2003) of the Poumai Naga Tribe Recognition Demand Committee, there are 77 Poumai-recognised villages (Andrew, 2003, pp. 3-9).

There are a few villages in the Poumai land which attract attention due to historical and cultural significance. Saranamai/Sümai village is acclaimed as the first place of settlement after the dispersal from Makhel, the common ancestral village of the Tenyime Nagas. Naga peoples such as the Memei (Mao), Angami, Chakesang and Zeiliangrong claim this as their place of origin. Koide/Namai is another place which the Lepaona group claims as its place of gathering after dispersal from Makhel and Saranamai. Liyai Khullen (Zhaimai) is an old historical village among the Poumai Nagas with various historical remains like ancient stone monoliths, water pools, banyan trees, male and female houses. Oinam is another important village of the Poumai Nagas where mud pots were made called *Ngulie*. These pots were used for various religious rituals, cooking and storing water. Purul is the home of indigenous games *Toutou* and wrestling. *Toutou* is played during the New Year festival and wrestling is traditionally played on the eve of paddy transplantation festival called *Paoki*. Phuba Thapham (*Khoubu*) is believed to be the place where Proumai forefathers, descendents of Proupuzhi, made a first stop as they journeyed to their present villages.

2. The Poumai Homeland

The land where Poumais are concentrated is a mountainous

region located in the north and north-east part of Senapati district of Manipur and slopes towards the south along with the rivers and streams that flow mainly towards the south. The general altitude of the Poumai land ranges from about 1060-1790 metres above the sea level. But there are also some higher mountain ranges. Important peaks of the region are Houdu (2,500m), Khouchi (2,345m), Ngapu and Vouze. Thus the Poumais are essentially highland people.

The Poumai land falls under the Northern Hilly Region, as per the *Regional Divisions of India – a Cartographic Analysis Series, Manipur,* published by the Registrar General, India in the year 1980. The geology of the area is related to Barail Series and Simsang Formation and Jaintia Series and Disang Series with faults and thrusts; because of this there are many earthquakes, mostly minor, in the region. Soils are *Udalfs*, very fertile soils formed in humid areas, under a hardwood forest cover, now sadly lost to a great degree. It has a clay-enriched subsoil and relatively high native fertility. There are also *Ochrepts*, thin, light coloured mountain soils. During the winter months frozen snow can be seen on the mountain peaks in the morning hours (Directorate of Census Operations Manipur, 2011).

The Senapati District in general and Poumai country in particular enjoy a very pleasant climate throughout the year. The temperature is neither very hot nor very cold. The seasons can be very conveniently classified into spring, the rainy season, autumn and winter. The months of March and October are the most pleasant months of the year. April and May are the hottest months. Temperatures rise from March onwards and day temperatures are highest in April and May. From the month of October the temperatures begin to dip and by the beginning of November winter season starts and continues up to the end of February. December and January are the coldest months of

the year. Rainfall and sunshine are abundant in the area and the land enjoys adequate rainfall which supports different varieties of vegetation throughout the year. It has an average annual rainfall of 1135.5 mm. Naturally, there is a large number of streams and some important rivers.

The Barak River, locally called *Vorei* or *Avourei* and its tributaries, is the most important river in the region. From its source near the Poumai village of Liyai, it drains the northern and north-western part of the Senapati district. From Liyai Khullen (Zhaimai), it follows a south-western direction up to Kangpokpi, then turns north up to Lairouching, from where it follows a western course eventually into Bangladesh, meeting on its way a number of tributaries. The River Iril, locally called *Phaomai Sorie* originates from Lakhamai village, and flows through Ngamju Village. The river then flows southward through other villages till it joins the Imphal river. The Ngairei or Laini River flows from southeast towards the north of the region that demarcates as the boundary line between the Chakhesang area of Nagaland and the Poumai area. It eventually turns its courses to the east and flows into Myanmar (Burma).

As highland people, the Poumais originally depended on subsistence agriculture with shifting cultivation as the principal method for growing enough food for themselves. But in recent times, many have laboriously created terraces for settled wet paddy cultivation. In the Poumai area, the plantation of paddy begins by mid-May and goes until the beginning of July. Harvest of paddy is completed by the month of November. In addition, the Poumais grow cabbages and other vegetables as commercial crops, and of course, maintain kitchen gardens for family use. According to the Census of 2011, agriculture is the principal economic activity of the Poumais and cultivators constituted 74.96% of the total workers in the district of Senapati with

Paomata Circle having the highest proportion of cultivators with 90.91%, followed by Purul with 82.99%.

3. Social Organisation and Cultural Features

Poumai villages tend to be autonomous and self-rule is usually through a council of elder men. Each village has between 2-6 *khels* or neighbourhoods where a particular clan or clans dwell. These clans are actually the most important source of unity amongst the Poumais because the clans are usually located in more than one village. Within each village the clans form the governing structure, with one or two representatives from each *khel* sitting at the village council.

As one might guess, the entire social system is patriarchal. Traditionally, a Poumai family was ideally large enough to provide many workers for the cultivation of a family's fields. The family was monogamous and nuclear. The Poumais had no tradition of child marriage, dowry, or bride price.

As already noted, in the past, people in general were cultivators. Hence they depended a lot on the monsoon. And to make sure that they had a good monsoon they believed in the Almighty God who controls the nature, the sun, rain, and insects. Therefore every action of the farmer began with appeasing God with the observation of a ritual before preparing the soil, plantation, harvest and other facets of their life. The people are religious, we might even say superstitious, because so many of their requests to God as Christians are for 'this worldly' things like good crops, good health, and good families.

During the time of the emergence of these tales and stories, each Poumai village used to have dormitories: *Khekizii* where young men slept together and *Loukizii* for young women. The boys' dormitory (*morung* is a common name) served as the means of education where boys learned warrior skills, leadership,

teamwork, and traditional stories, songs and dances. Similarly, young women in the *Loukizii* learned appropriate skills for their role in society, not the least of which was the art of weaving. It was here as well that boys from a *Khekizii* would come to visit and court their future wives.

In every village there seems to have been many orphans. They suffered greatly due to discrimination from their peers and society. In the society there were also people who were very rich and tried to get social recognition and approval through sponsoring Feasts of Merit. Through this act they obtained a status in society and were considered blessed, wise and powerful.

The people had some faint knowledge and belief in life after death here on earth. The folktales present the dreams, the tele-communication between the living and the dead. At the time of burial of the dead, relatives bury the belongings of the dead along with them, and also place some food and drinks on the tomb as food for the journey to the land of the dead.

Folktales about animals were very imaginative and had a message to convey. In fact many animal tales turned into proverbs and sayings. For example, people who were too gullible were known as stags without a gall bladder. The story of 'the crab and the fowl' is referred to when people begin to blame one another. The narration of folktales was used as a medium of education for the folks, lessons to learn and stories to be enjoyed for leisure. Learning of folksongs was an entertainment as well as an art to be acquired by every young man and woman.

4. Festivals and Cultural Events

The festivals and cultural events of the Poumais are very closely linked with the agricultural seasons. The feast that is celebrated at the beginning of the sowing of seeds is called

Taithounü or *Marunü. Duh* is a ritual observation which falls in the months of March/ April and is performed asking the deity to bless seeds and plants. The sowing of paddy is heralded with the celebration called *Paonü* or *Paoki,* and once the plantation is over, the long and heavy days of work are crowned with the celebration of *Laonü.* Around the month of September when the new moon appears the people observe the *Nge* ritual. It is a ritual observation praying for healthy paddy, and preservation from being affected by pestilence. After the harvest people gather the paddy and store it in a barn. The inauguration of the new rice called *Baoloutouyu* is preceded by a sacred ritual of smearing the four corners of the barn with a special type of crab and fish. *Thounü* is the much-awaited New Year celebration for the Poumais where there is much fanfare and cultural celebration, social interaction and family reunion. It is held after the harvest as it is the best part of the year when there is abundance of rice to eat and to brew rice beer. Rice beer is an important part of every ritual performed and festive celebration. It is to be noted that, though the majority of the Poumais have converted to Christianity, the agricultural festivals are still observed with great pomp and gaiety. However, at this time, Christian festivals like Christmas, New Year, Good Friday and Easter Sunday have taken a prime of place in society.

Here it is important also to mention the *Zhosouyu*, or Feast of Merit, so important among the Naga communities in general, and certainly the Poumais, where it still exists. There are actually different types of feasts, usually given in a specific order first for the clan, then the village, then the entire area. Men who can afford the largest feast were obviously the most successful in the community. Sponsors of the Feast would be rewarded with a special cloak, the *Zhosousa* or *Zhosa*, and would

be allowed special decorations on their house. These feasts, of course, were the means for maintaining the egalitarian Poumai culture: riches were not accumulated, except for these feasts in which the bounty was shared with others (Thohe Pou, 2009). It was in Liyai Khullen village that one of the last much exalted and honoured Feast of Merit celebrations was conducted in 2004.

Head hunting was a feature of all Naga tribes. As will be seen in some of the tales that follow, this is also true of the Poumais. Volumes, of course, have been written on this custom that was central to the life of Nagas and many other hill communities. A persons' head was believed to hold the vitality of the individual in life or death. Thus taking a head and bringing it to one's home village brought an infusion of power and energy on which growth and agricultural success depended. Taking heads was another means of gaining honour and status in the community, much like the feasts of merit mentioned earlier. A head brought as trophy was a service to the whole village and those who brought one at great risk to themselves were duly esteemed. Any village was a possible target for head hunting, which obviously led to quite isolated Poumai villages, always on hilltops to protect themselves with elaborate defence systems (Thohe Pou, 2009).

5. Collecting Folktales – My Personal Experience

The Poumai Nagas are one of the biggest tribes in the Senapati District of Manipur. Saranamai, Koide and Thapham are important villages in the history of migration and dispersal from Makhel. The Poumai Nagas proudly celebrate various age-old agricultural festivals, observe the different phases of the moon for performing traditional rituals, observe the rites of initiation of children into society, and preserve other aspects

of their ancient heritage.

I really enjoyed every bit of gathering the folktales that are presented in this book. First of all, I was very glad to make contact with the elders, who are the bridge between the old and the new generations and the storehouse of folk knowledge. Secondly, listening and recording the folktales unravelled to me a world of knowledge, of the history of the people, its outlook towards nature, God and society. The stories revealed what governed the daily life of the people, the socio-religious practices, various rules that guided the conservation of forests and the agricultural conditions of the people. These are all precious things that the Poumais are beginning to lose. How can we know who we are if we don't know where we are from?

In my search to hear and learn folktales, I realised that most people, even most of the Poumais, either do not know or have forgotten their traditional folktales. Even if they do know some of the stories, they are not able to narrate individual stories in their entirety. Only a handful of the elders and a few teachers who were educated long ago are able to narrate them well. Worse still is the condition of the art of singing folksongs. Hardly anybody can sing the different types of folksongs. I have a feeling that the art of singing folksongs is going to be a 'lost art and a relic of the past' if it is not taken up as a challenge to revive it. Otherwise, Poumai folksongs may exist only in books as some antique history.

Though there is an uneasy lament among the people that the advent of Christianity and the western system of education has brought about the erosion of traditional and cultural practices among the younger generations, yet it is not too late to use these same instruments of education to get into scholarly study, record and preserve the cultural and traditional knowledge of the Poumai Nagas.

My hope is that this collection of folktales will go beyond preservation. In many ways the folktales tell the Poumai people where they came from. But they also tell other people where the Poumais come from. If such a knowledge can be a bridge between a small but proud people of the mountains in North East India and the larger world, this collection will more than serve its purpose.

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MYTHS

1. The Myth of Dzüliamosürou

There is a belief among the Shüpfomai (Mao and Poumai) Nagas that man, spirit and tiger were the offspring of a mythical woman called Dzüliamosürou. One day as she was resting under the banyan tree, a white cloud from the east appeared and covered her and she felt a warmth over her private parts and thus she conceived and gave birth to god (*Ra*), tiger (*Khao*) and man (*Mai*). Among them Ra was the eldest, Khao the second and Mai was the youngest. Their mother brought them up with great love and care, though not without difficulty because of the absence of their father. Each of the brothers exhibited their own unique character and identity. In nature, offsprings are begotten through the union of male and female. The brothers had never seen their father, so they pleaded with their mother to show them their father.

The mother called all of them together and told them to watch her. She took a cup of wine, blew out a little on the right, a little on the left of the *Rüphi* (the central pillar of a house) and called on the father, *"Ra, Ra, Pu Teithrai, Teiho, mangao pei."* (I pray you god, please show their father wind and cloud). As they offered a libation to god and prayed to reveal their father, suddenly, wind and cloud came from the east and

filled the courtyard of their house. Their mother pointed out, "See, there is your father." The boys could not comprehend but never asked her to show them their father anymore.

As they grew up, they had various competitions among themselves. One day, they decided to undertake a competition to decide who would inherit the home of the parents. They decided to settle it through a race. The mother was called to be the referee. Mai was physically weaker of the two but he was always the scheming one. He always challenged the others for various competitions. Mai understood his position, so he went and asked his mother what he should do. The mother advised him to make use of the bow and arrow. Before they could fix the day for the competition, Mai would quietly move away from their company and practice shooting. When the time for the competition came, the mother lined them up at the starting point, and shouted "Get set! Go!" Mai immediately pulled out his bow and shot an arrow straight at the finishing point. Thus Mai was declared the winner who would inherit the ancestral home.

Their mother was getting old and sickly, and so they decided to take turns looking after their mother. While one of them looked after the mother, the other two would work in the field and tend the cattle. When the eldest, Ra (spirit), stayed back to take care of their mother, the mother would experience a high temperature and feel tired. She was not able to rest properly because she would be constantly woken up by the heat of Ra's body. Her energy would be completely drained out. She never felt comfortable in his presence.

Now it was the turn of Khao to look after the mother. The restless tiger constantly shifted his mother and changed her

position to find out the best portion of meat in her body. The preoccupation of Khao was the dinner he would have when she died. When Khao spent his day with the mother, she became sicklier than ever.

When Mai took care of the mother, she felt calm and rested. She would look much better and healthier. Mai would cook nice food for her and take good care of her. He would go to the garden and pluck chilly and make a nice soup (*Khaojü*) for her. She always waited for the day Mai would take care of her.

One day the mother felt a kind of premonition that her time had come to leave this world. She wished that Mai would be there at her bedside, and so even though it was the turn of Khao to take care of her, she quietly requested Mai to stay back with her, fearing that Khao would eat her body. Mai managed to convince Khao and stayed back with the mother. Khao reluctantly went out for his usual chores.

When both Ra and Khao had gone to the field for work, the mother requested one last favour from her son Mai. She whispered faintly, "I know my time has come. When I die hide my body from Khao lest he exhume and eat my body." She then slowly slipped away to eternity in her sleep. Mai was very sad and he cried inconsolably. However there was not much time to mourn for he had to hurry and fulfil his mother's last wish of hiding her body from Khao.

He was clueless as to how he might hide his mother's body, because the common custom was to bury the body under the hearth. After much pondering, he decided to dig two graves, one outside the house and one under the hearth. He first dug the grave under the hearth, buried her and placed the tripod stones of the hearth over the grave and made a fresh fire. The

smoke produced by the fire would cover the smell of the human body. Then he also dug a grave outside the house and filled it with lots of thorns and shrubs.

In the evening when Ra and Khao came back, they found their mother missing. Mai told them that she had passed away soon after they left for work, and that he had buried her outside the house. When Khao entered the house he was sniffing deliriously and trying to dig the mud near the hearth saying, "I smell some meat here." Mai was perturbed and gave a hard knock on his forehead saying, "Don't be stupid, Khao." In response, Khao immediately put its head down and went out.

Khao pretended to be very sad, and wanted by any means to see the mother's body. He wanted to pay her his last respects. He decided to exhume the body from the grave. Khao dug out the mud from the grave, but as it was filled with thorns and shrubs, Khao's paws began to bleed profusely. He licked his paws to stop the bleeding but as he could not resist the temptation to see the body, the tiger began to dig the grave again. After some time when Khao was nearing the bottom of the grave he realised that he was cheated by Mai. He got so angry that henceforth their relationship began to sour.

As days passed by, the relationship between Khao and Mai was getting more and more tense, and even Ra was affected by the tension. There was no peace in the house. They were picking on each other unnecessarily. So Mai thought of a plan to send Khao off. One day Mai innocuously put this question to Khao, "What is the thing that you fear most in your life?" Khao thought for a while and said, "I don't fear anybody except fire and the sound of the horn." Getting a clue to his scheme, Mai thought for a while and quietly lit a bundle of bamboo and

tied it to Khao's tail. He then took the *Bii* (a tall plant with hollow stalk which makes a loud noise like that of a bugle when blown into), placed it near the tiger's ear and blasted it. Khao was stunned and shocked, and dashed off in any direction that his legs took him. He bounded off and ran till he broke his neck and was breathless. That is how Mai and Khao separated from each other.

And so, even today whenever there is a misunderstanding between persons, and reconciliation becomes an impossibility they say, "We shall part ways like Mai and Khao." And traditionally it is not forbidden for the Poumai Nagas to build a house over a tomb. The reason for tigers walking with their head bent is also explained by the above story. To this day it is said, when a man encounters Khao in the forest he utters, "*Tsümai sü, neh bo chuh, a bo chuh.*" (Elder one, your path is different and my path is different). In this way the tiger will go on his way without harming human beings.

Next came the turn of Ra and Mai to depart. It was the wish of the mother that her favourite child Mai should occupy good and beautiful hills while Ra should stay deep in the forest, among the woods and the rocks where Mai could never survive. One day Ra and Mai had an exchange of words. Ra asked Mai whether he should eat only ripe chilli or green and tender chilli. Mai imprudently replied that it was his wish to eat a chilli whether ripe or unripe. On hearing this Ra decreed that Mai's life can be taken anytime, at youth or at old age. Mai retorted that Ra also should die, if he were seen by Mai before Ra saw him. Earlier Mai could see everything that Ra was doing and where he was going. But one day when Mai was asleep, Ra quietly plucked the eyes of a dog and exchanged them with

those of Mai. When Mai got up, he could not see Ra anymore. Ra left home and went to dwell in the deep forest, among the bamboo groves and rocky cliffs.

Because of this, people believe that the dogs can see Ra and they begin to howl and cry whenever Ra comes around.

LEGENDS